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Pittsburgh District

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What's the Significance of the Leetsdale Archaeology Site?

The 12-acre archaeological site at Leetsdale, Pennsylvania, is important for a number of reasons:

- No other site of this type has been excavated under controlled conditions along the upper Ohio River in Pennsylvania. This site has the potential to add new and important information about the people who lived in the Upper Ohio River Valley and the Appalachian Plateau Province during the last 8,000 years. It is expected that the information gained from this site will serve as a basis for comparison for future archaeology work in this region of the United States.
- The site was occupied off and on over a long period of time. Archaeological studies indicate that people have been sporadically camping within this same 12-acre area over the last 7,000-8,000 years. When people first came to the Leetsdale site to live in short-term camps, this [landform](#) was actually the high area of an island within the Ohio River. About 7,500 years ago the ground surface would have been about 14 feet lower in elevation than it is now.
- The site encapsulates many discrete occupations. This site has been subjected to frequent floods that left behind an accumulation of alluvial soils. Each flood that left behind new soils sealed off the older ground surface and, with it, any occupation remains of people that once camped at this site. Such a flood event created what might be seen as a separate "time capsule." Some of these time capsules might not have any evidence of occupations (culturally sterile soils). On some of these, the occupation surface may have been partially scoured away by floodwaters, leaving only the bottoms of cultural features to indicate that there was once a camp site there (disturbed occupations). Some of these "time capsules" still have the living surface and the features intact. These types of "time capsules" with intact occupation surfaces provide the kind of information that archaeologists can use to answer a lot of questions about the people that camped there.
- There are many different occupations that date to different time periods. Archaeologists are able to study the changes in the occupations at the site over time by comparing and contrasting

these occupations.

- Several Middle Archaic occupations in different strata or "time capsules" have been documented. The Middle Archaic refers to the period from approximately 6,000 BC to 4,000 BC (or 6,000 to 8,000 years ago). We know less about this time period than any other period in North American prehistory. This site has the potential to allow archaeologists to make leaps in information and knowledge about this particular period of the past. It will tell archaeologists how these people lived at that time.
- There are intact subsurface structural remnants of a 19th century [brick works](#) that can provide insights into this industry. In addition, a well-known 19th century religious sect, the [Harmonists](#), owned the brick works.
- There is evidence of [Early Woodland](#) occupations. Most of the information that we currently know about this time period (1,100 BC-100 BC, or 3,100-2,100 years ago) comes from ceremonial site excavations. This site has the potential to provide information on other aspects of life during this time.
- Archaeologists found a cluster of small projectile points, commonly referred to as 'bird' points because of their small size (usually 0.5 inch to 1.5 inch in size). These points date to about 1,800 BC and are typically found on sites located in Illinois, Indiana, and the lower Ohio River Valley. This appears to represent the easternmost find of these points and may indicate that a group of Native Americans from the Midwest traveled up the Ohio River and camped at this site.

[Click here to read a student's perspective of the significance of the Harmony Brick Works](#)

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